SHIV NADAR SCHOOL
MODEL UNITED NATIONS CONFERENCE

Background Guide for the World Health Organization (WHO)

Committee Overview and Mandate:

About the WHO

The World Health Organization (WHO) is a specialized agency of the United Nations reporting to the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)[1]. The WHO is the coordinating authority on international healthcare issues within the United Nations (UN) system, promoting the attainment of the highest possible level of health by all people[2]. WHO is active in six intersecting areas of work: assisting its 194 Member States in the development of their respective health systems; the eradication of non-communicable diseases (NCDs); the promotion of good health in individuals; the prevention, treatment, and care for communicable diseases; the preparedness, surveillance and response with respect to international health emergencies; and the extension of corporate services to the organization's public and private partners[3]. The activities of the WHO span multiple policy areas and are informed by the organization's key guiding principle, which defines health as a state of complete physical, mental, and social well-being and not merely the absence of disease or infirmity.[4]

The WHO's 1946 constitution established the organization as a specialized agency of the UN in accordance with Article 57 of the Charter of the UN[5]. Notwithstanding its status as an autonomous organization within the UN system, the WHO operates within the purview of the ECOSOC, which is responsible for coordinating the work of specialized agencies on an intergovernmental level[6]. Accordingly, the WHO reports to ECOSOC in accordance with an agreement between the organization and the UN[7]. The WHO's Director-General is a member of the UN System Chief Executive Board for Coordination, which comprises the 29 executive heads of the UN, including its funds and programs, the specialized agencies, the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund, as well as the World Trade Organization and the International Atomic Energy Agency[8].

The WHO's Work

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[1] WHO, Address by Dr Margaret Chan, Director-General, to the Sixty-eighth World Health Assembly (A68/3), 2015.
[2] WHO, About WHO, 2015; WHO, Basic Documents – 48th ed. Including amendments adopted up to 31 December 2014, 2014. 3 WHO, What we do, 2015.
[3] Ibid.
[4] WHO, Constitution of WHO: principles, 2015.
[5] Charter of the United Nations, 1945; WHO, Constitution of the World Health Organization, 1946, p. 2. 14 UN DPI, The United Nations System, 2015.
[6] Ibid.
[7] WHO, Constitution of the World Health Organization, 1946, p. 7.
[8] UNSCEB, Who we are, 2015.

The Constitution of the World Health Organization was adopted in July 1946[9]. Following a complete breakdown of international health cooperation during the Second World War, an Interim Commission was tasked with continuing the activities of existing institutions until 26 signatories of the WHO's constitution had ratified the document[10]. After coming into force in April 1948, the World Health Assembly (WHA), the organization's decision-making body comprising all WHO Member States, convened in Geneva on 24 June 1948 for the first time[11]. Although the WHO largely remained an advocate for health research throughout its first decade, its operative programs gradually expanded in the following years, exemplified by the launch of its smallpox eradication campaign in 1966[12].

The adoption of Resolution *WHA19.16* of 13 May 1966 by the WHA, calling for a worldwide smallpox eradication program under the leadership of the WHO's Director-General, represents a milestone in the WHO's history as it marked the organization's first global immunization campaign that eventually succeeded in eliminating the disease in 1980[13]. Another defining moment for the WHO was the 1978 International Conference on Primary Health Care in Alma-Ata, Kazakhstan, which declared access to primary health care for all as the organization's key strategic objective, while also linking health to social and economic development[14]. The conference essentially refined the concept of primary health care, not only by highlighting the need for greater equity in access to health services within and between states, but also by emphasizing that health is a key value for every human being, which brought the attainment of health for all states to the forefront of national and international capacity building agendas, including especially for developing Member States[15]. The Declaration of Alma-Ata (1978) served as the basis for the WHO's *Global Strategy for Health for All by the Year 2000* (1981), which aimed to achieve universal primary healthcare, a goal that is still being pursued today[16].

Improving Coordination of Health Services in Outbreaks and Emergencies

Background

Crisis-affected countries suffer from situations like disease outbreaks, natural disasters, and conflict. Whether or not a crisis is a health-related issue, it can leave vulnerable populations even more at risk. Disease outbreaks are a constant global threat, especially for the record 130 million people who need humanitarian assistance[17]. An emergency is defined as "a sudden and usually unforeseen event that calls for immediate measures to minimize its adverse consequences[18]". The WHO has created programs like the WHO's *Health Emergencies Programme*, which is governed by one workforce, one budget, one line of accountability, one set of processes/systems, and one

[9] WHO, Origin and development of health cooperation, 2015.
[10] Ibid.
[11] Ibid.
[12] Charles, Origins, History, and Achievements of the World Health Organization, 1968, p. 295.
[13] WHO, The Third Ten Years of the World Health Organization – 1968-1977, 2008, pp. 177-181.
[14] Ibid., pp. 303-304.
[15] Ibid., p. 1.
[16] McCarthy, A brief history of the World Health Organization, 2002, p. 1111; WHO, Global Strategy for Health for All by the Year 2000, 1981; Declaration of Alma-Ata, 1978.
[17] "WHO's New Health Emergencies Programme". World Health Organization. N.p., 2016. Web.
[18] World Health Organization. Glossary Of Humanitarian Terms. ReliefWeb Project, 2008. Print.

set of benchmarks,[19] to address outbreaks and emergencies. This program aims for the rapid response and exchange of information among WHO organizations. As of 6 March 2016, regional directors of the WHO met to discuss better communication tactics for this program[20]. The WHO also relies on the *Global Outbreak Alert and Response Network* (GOARN) to collaborate with existing institutes and networks for technical expertise and skills[21]. Most recently, the WHO has responded to the COVID-19 pandemic, leading efforts to establish and direct *COVAX*, one of the four pillars of the *Access to Covid-19 Tools Accelerator*. The *Cluster Approach* is also necessary to respond to emergencies, enabling multiple organizations to coordinate more effectively in such circumstances. Currently, 23 countries have an active health cluster to help approximately 67.3 million people worldwide[22].

Financing Outbreaks and Emergencies

The WHO is seeking significant additional funding to scale up operations in 2022-2023[23] in light of the ongoing COVID-19 pandemic, such emergent threats as monkey pox, and the health consequences of the crises such as Ukrainian emergency. This includes securing additional contributions to the Contingency Fund for Emergencies (CFE) and the Emergencies Programme for the Western Pacific. WHO activities have supported such efforts in the past as addressing to a Cholera outbreak in Yemen, Hurricane Matthew in Haiti, the outbreak of Rift Valley Fever in Niger, the humanitarian crisis in Yemen, and the public health impact of extreme climate events, including the El Nino weather pattern.[24] The CFE was established on 26 May 2015 to temporarily fund the initial response to an emergency until other financing sources was developed[25]. The framework for financing comes from the 12th General Programme of Work, but the aim is a fully funded Programme Budget. The WHO relies on voluntary support from Member States and other partners for funding, but there currently is a significant funding gap.[26]

Relevant Organization Transparency and Partnership

The *GOARN* ensures technical expertise and other skills are on the ground where and when they are needed most. Some organizations that participate in GOARN are UN Organizations, the Red Cross (International Committee of the Red Cross, International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies, and national societies) and international humanitarian nongovernmental organizations[27]. One critical piece of work for GOARN is implementing the *Guiding Principles for International Outbreak Alert and Response*, which aims at providing more international assistance for diseases. GOARN accomplishes its goals by ensuring partners make every effort to

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[19] World Health Organization. WHO's New Health Emergency Programme. World Health Organization, 2016. Print.
[20] World Health Organization. Progress Report on the Development of the Health Emergency Programme. WHO, 2016. Print.
[21] "WHO | Global Outbreak Alert & Response Network". Who.int. N.p., 2005. Web.
[22] "Health Cluster". World Health Organization. Web.
[23] World Health Organization. WHO's New Health Emergency Programme. World Health Organization, 2016. Print.
[24] "Contingency Fund For Emergencies Income And Allocations". World Health Organization. N.p., 2017. Web.
[25] "Contingency Fund For Emergencies". 2015. Presentation.
[26] "Donor Centre". World Health Organization. N.p., 2016. Web.
[27] "WHO GOARN Programme," Last Modified January 2017, Accessed April 24, 2017, http://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org/tools_citationguide.html

ensure the effective coordination of their participation and support of outbreak response. One common practice is through using Field Epidemiology Programs, which train local personnel on proper containment and treatment techniques[28]. A success of GOARN can be seen in the response to the Ebola outbreak in West Africa. Due to the collaboration of the involved parties, an experimental vaccine known as rVSV-ZEBOV was produced. This is proving to have significant effectiveness against one of the most lethal pathogens[29].

The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (UNOCHA) is the leading UN body behind the Cluster Approach. This came out of the *2005 Humanitarian Reform*, which focused on overall productivity of partnerships among humanitarian organizations[30]. The Cluster Approach helps select leaders for WHO missions such as natural disaster response within countries. These leaders are part of a cluster, which report back to the other cluster of leaders for different organizations such as United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) and the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees[31].

Prevention

The prevention of outbreaks and emergencies at the source is a key aspect of improving coordination of health services in outbreaks and emergencies. This can be done through primary and secondary prevention measures. Primary prevention includes providing immunizations, information concerning medical health risks, and dental hygiene services and education. For example, measles outbreaks are linked primarily to a lack of vaccinations. In 2015, there were 134,200 measles deaths globally[32]. In major Ebola outbreak areas cases of measles have increased drastically due to a significant drop in immunization in these areas. Immunization is just one of many aspects of primary prevention.

Secondary prevention deals with early detection that improves the chances for positive health outcomes, such as increasing population based screening for early detection of outbreaks, establishing educational and social communication activities aimed at promoting healthy conditions, lifestyles, behavior, and environments, and capacity building among states. While primary prevention activities may be implemented independently of capacity-building in other health care services, this is not the case for secondary prevention[33]. One way secondary prevention can be implemented is through public health surveillance. Public health surveillance is the continuous and systematic collection, analysis, and interpretation of health-related data needed for the planning, implementation, and evaluation of public health practices. The Integrated Disease

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[28] "WHO Guiding Principles for International Outbreak Alert and Response," Last Modified January 2017, Accessed April 24, 2017

[29] Tarik Jašarević, "Final trial results confirm Ebola vaccine provides high protection against disease," *WHO Department of Communications* (2016), Accessed April 24, 2017 http://www.who.int/mediacentre/news/releases/2016/ebola-vaccine-results/en/

[30] "UNOCHA Cluster Approach Homepage," Last Modified January 2017, Accessed April 24, 2017 http://www.unocha.org/what-we-do/coordination-tools/cluster-coordination

[31] "UNOCHA Leadership," Last Modified January 2017, Accessed April 24, 2017 http://www.unocha.org/what-we-do/coordination/leadership/overview

[32] http://www.who.int/mediacentre/factsheets/fs286/en/

[33] http://www.emro.who.int/about-who/public-health-functions/health-promotion-disease-prevention.html

Surveillance (IDS) system uses public health surveillance to serve as an early warning system (EWS) for identifying potential public health emergencies in Africa.

Conclusion

Delegates should consider questions such as: how can the WHO increase its effectiveness while minimizing costs? What methods can be introduced into systems like GOARN or the Cluster Approach to improve collaboration among relevant organizations involved in promoting global health? Finally, what can contribute to expanding prevention measures, whether it be expanding the availability of vaccines or the quality medical practices? Today, many experts within the international field address these questions, but new diseases and other medical issues will arise in the future, which call for better coordination and management of the WHO.

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1. http://www.who.int/about/who_reform/emergency-capacities/WHO-one-emergency-programme-24October2016.pdf?ua=1 (Health Emergencies Programme and Funding)
2. http://www.who.int/about/who_reform/emergency-capacities/contingency-fund/contribution/en/ (Contingency Fund for Emergencies)
3. http://www.who.int/about/who_reform/emergency-capacities/contingency-fund/Contingency-Fund-Emergencies.pdf?ua=1 (CFE)
4. http://www.who.int/hac/donorinfo/en/ (Funding Gap)

Transparency/Partnership

1. http://www.who.int/ihr/alert_and_response/outbreak-network/en/ (GOARN)
2. http://www.who.int/csr/outbreaknetwork/guidingprinciples/en/ (Guiding Principles)
3. http://www.who.int/mediacentre/news/releases/2016/ebola-vaccine-results/en/ (Ebola Vaccine
4. https://www.unocha.org/legacy/what-we-do/coordination-tools/cluster-coordination (Cluster Approach)

Prevention

1. http://www.who.int/mediacentre/factsheets/fs286/en/ (Prevention)
2. http://www.emro.who.int/about-who/public-health-functions/health-promotion-disease-prevention.html (Prevention)

Regional Organizations

African Union-

https://www.au.int/

Arab League-

http://www.arableagueonline.org/

Association of South East Asian Nations-

http://asean.org/

Asian Cooperation Dialogue-

http://www.acd-dialogue.org/

European Union-

https://europa.eu/european-union/index_en

Economic Community of West African States-

http://www.ecowas.int/

Organization of American States-

http://www.oas.org/en/

Pacific Islands Forum-

http://www.forumsec.org/

Union of South American Nations-

http://www.unasur.int/en

International Agencies

Europol-

https://www.europol.europa.eu/

International Police Association-

http://www.ipa-iac.org/

INTERPOL-

https://www.interpol.int/

International Criminal Court-

https://www.icc-cpi.int/

United Nations Entities

International Peace and Security-

http://www.un.org/en/sections/priorities/international-peace-and-security/

Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs

http://www.unocha.org/

United Nations Assistance Mission to Iraq-

http://www.uniraq.org/index.php?lang=en

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http://www.un.org/en/charter-united-nations/

United Nations Country Team Iraq-

http://www.uniraq.com/index.php?option=com_k2&view=item&layout=item&id=944&Itemid=479&lang=en

United Nations Developmental Assistance Framework-

https://www.un.org/ecosoc/sites/www.un.org.ecosoc/files/files/en/qcpr/doco-summary-brief-on-undaf-march2016.pdf

United Nations Department of Peacekeeping Operations-http://www.un.org/en/peacekeeping/about/dpko/

United Nations Department of Political Affairs-
http://www.un.org/undpa/en

United Nations Development Programme in Nigeria-
http://www.ng.undp.org/

United Nations Office of the Special Advisor on Africa
http://www.un.org/en/africa/osaa/

United Nations Peacekeeping-
http://www.un.org/en/peacekeeping/

United Nations Security Council-
http://www.un.org/en/sc/

United Nations Security Council Counter-Terrorism Committee-
https://www.un.org/sc/ctc/

United Nations Security Council Documents-
http://www.un.org/en/sc/documents/

United Nations Supervision Mission in Syria-
http://www.un.org/en/peacekeeping/missions/unsmis/